



Festive atmosphere: Drones, drums, and fireworks light up the grid at the Saudi GP. GETTY IMAGES

GP in 2010. The fifth round of the 2025 F1 season coincided with the fifth Saudi Arabian Grand Prix at the Jeddah Corniche street track. A controversial five-second penalty to defending champion and pole-sitter Verstappen eventually tilted the race in Piastri's favour.

McLaren looked in a league of its own during the practice session on Saturday. But as temperatures dipped after nightfall, Verstappen delivered when it counted – beating Piastri by just one-hundredth of a second in qualifying.

The Moves That Mattered

When the lights went off in Jeddah, Piastri got off the line quicker than Verstappen, leaving the latter on the back foot going into Turn 1. The Dutchman held firm on the outside and cut across the chicane to stay ahead.

Verstappen argued he had no room to make the corner, but stewards disagreed, handing him a five-second penalty which he served during his pit stop.

He ultimately finished 2.843

seconds behind Piastri after 50 laps on the 6.174 km circuit – a result that might have flipped had the penalty not been imposed.

Ferrari's Charles Leclerc earned his first podium of the season, a reward for his tyre management. Lacking the outright pace to fight the leaders, he stretched his medium tyre stint until lap 29, long after rubber marks had settled into the asphalt.

An aggressive push on hards in the second stint allowed him to edge out Mercedes' George Russell and stay ahead of a flying Norris, who climbed from 10th to fourth on a hard-to-medium strategy.

Norris salvaged 12 points after a brush with the wall in Q3 cut short

his qualifying session and dashed hopes of a front-row start.

Kimi Antonelli and Lewis Hamilton had uneventful runs to sixth and seventh, finishing ahead of the two Williams and Racing Bulls' Isack Hadjar.

Aston Martin, Haas, Alpine, and Kick Sauber left Jeddah empty-handed.

Vying for the Big League

In Formula Two, MP Motorsport's Richard Verschoor executed the alternate strategy to perfection, finishing ahead of pole-sitter DAMS' Jack Crawford and ART's Victor Martins. The win vaulted Verschoor past fifth-placed Jose Maria Marti into the lead of the F2 Drivers' Championship.

« Verstappen got a 5-second penalty for gaining advantage off-track while battling Piastri at Turn 1 »